PARENT-CHILD RELATIONSHIP QUALITY, PARENTAL STRESS AND BEHAVIORAL PROBLEMS IN CHILDREN WITH AUTISM

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Introduction & Objective

Children with ASD often exhibit behavioral problems. These challenges contribute to elevated parental stress, which impacts the entire family system. This study uses the **Expressed Emotion (EE)** framework to evaluate how emotional relationship quality moderates this link.

Objective: To examine if positive relationship indicators buffer the impact of behavioral problems on stress, and whether this varies by diagnosis, gender, and child age.

Methodology

- **Participants:** 96 parents (48 ASD, 48 matched TD), matched for child age, gender, and IQ.
- **Key Measures:** Parenting Stress Index (PSI-4), Child Behavior Checklist (CBCL), Five Minute Speech Sample (FMSS).

Group Results

Behavior and stress were highly correlated in the ASD group (r=.58, p < .001), but no significant correlation was found in the TD group. Parents of children with ASD reported significantly more Emotional Over-Involvement (EOI) and fewer positive comments.

Metric	ASD Group Mean (SD)	TD (Control) Mean (SD)
Behavior Score	61.2 (29.5)***	15.6 (12.8)
Positive Comments	3.53 (2.79)	7.73 (3.25)***
EOI (Emotional Over-Involvement)	0.31 (0.47)**	0.06 (0.24)

**p < .05, **p < .01, ***p < .001*

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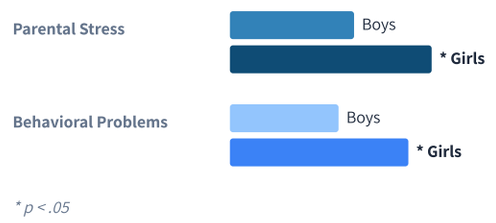
Gender Findings (ASD)

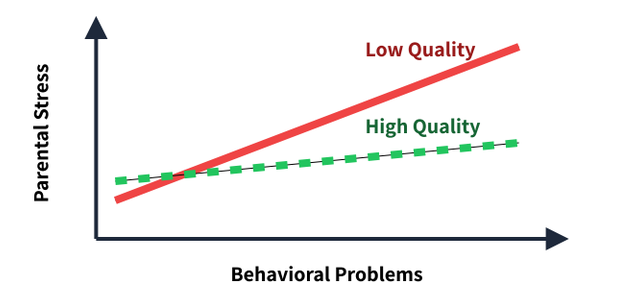
Within the ASD group, parents of girls reported significantly higher levels of stress and more **behavioral problems** compared to parents of boys (p=.05).



Moderation Model

Relationship quality buffers stress — but only during pre-school years!

Pre-school (Under 7): High relationship quality and positive comments significantly weakened the link between behavioral issues and stress.



Discussion & Conclusions

Resilience Buffer: Positive parent-child relationships may act as a "shock absorber", particularly during the early diagnostic window where high relationship quality significantly buffers stress (p < .05).

Critical Window: Parents of younger children (pre-school) reported significantly higher stress and expressed more criticism compared to parents of school-aged children (p < .001).

Gender Vulnerability: Girls with ASD exhibited more behavioral symptoms, highlighting the need for gender-sensitive clinical screening and early support.